Segue CRM: Legal Practice Module

User Guide & Step-by-Step Practical Manual

Application URL	https://crm-segueit.vercel.app
Who it's for	Principals, Solicitors, Paralegals, Trust Accountants and External Examiners
Rules it supports	Legal Profession Uniform Law (costs disclosure, s 170 and s 174) and Uniform General Rules (trust accounting), conflict-of-interest checks, verification of identity for conveyancing, AUSTRAC significant cash reporting

> **Important**
> The system helps you follow these rules, but the practice remains responsible for compliance. Check your processes against your law society's current guidance.

1. Introduction to the Legal Practice Module

The Legal Practice module runs a law firm's matters from first enquiry to file closure:

- clients and the other parties to a matter;
- automatic conflict checks;
- costs disclosure;
- time recorded in 6-minute units and billed to invoices;
- court dates and limitation dates, with reminders;
- a trust ledger that can't be overdrawn, and monthly trust reconciliations.

The module also enforces the key steps:

- **Before engaging on a matter:** conflicts must be cleared, and costs disclosure given where required.
- **Trust records:** they can't be altered after they're posted.
- **Closing a matter:** the matter can't close while there's unbilled time or money in trust.

Roles in your practice

Profile	What they can do
Principal	Every matter, party, conflict check, time entry, court date, invoice, client and organisation. Clears conflict checks that found matches (*Clear Conflicts*), records trust transactions (*Manage Trust Account*), writes off time, and signs off trust reconciliations. Invites clients to the portal, imports, exports and transfers records.

Profile	What they can do
Solicitor	Opens and runs their own matters: parties, conflict checks, time, court dates and invoices. Reads the trust ledger. Invites clients to the portal.
Paralegal	Supports solicitors on the matters shared with them: parties, court dates, conflict checks and time.
Trust Accountant	Records receipts, payments and transfers in the trust ledger (*Manage Trust Account*), prepares reconciliations, and reads every matter and time entry.
External Examiner	Reads matters and the trust records for the annual trust examination. Can't change anything.
System Administrator	The person who created the workspace. Everything, plus Setup.

The Responsible Solicitor and Supervising Principal named on a matter automatically get access to it.

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2. Getting Started & Interface Tour

Step 1: Sign in

1. Go to **https://crm-segueit.vercel.app**.
2. Enter your **Work e-mail** and **Password**, then click **Sign in**.
3. The first time you sign in, you set up **two-step verification** with an authenticator app. After that you enter its 6-digit code each time.

New colleagues receive an e-mail invitation to set their password. Each solicitor's practising certificate number is recorded on their user record (Setup → Users).

Step 2: The sidebar

Your workspace opens in the **Legal Practice** app. The sidebar lists:

- **Home:** shortcuts, your open matters, your tasks, recent records and the Practice Dashboard charts.
- **Enquiries:** prospective clients. Convert an enquiry to create the client.
- **Clients** and **Organisations**.
- **Matters:** every legal matter.
- **Time Entries:** recorded time.
- **Trust Ledger** and **Trust Reconciliations**.
- **Invoices.**
- **Client Requests:** questions and requests clients send from the client portal.
- **Calendar, Reports and Dashboards.**
- **Setup** (at the bottom, for administrators).

Parties, conflict checks and court dates live inside each matter (its **Related** tab). Collapse the sidebar with the arrow at its top or **Ctrl+B**. Every page except Home has a **Back** button at the top left.

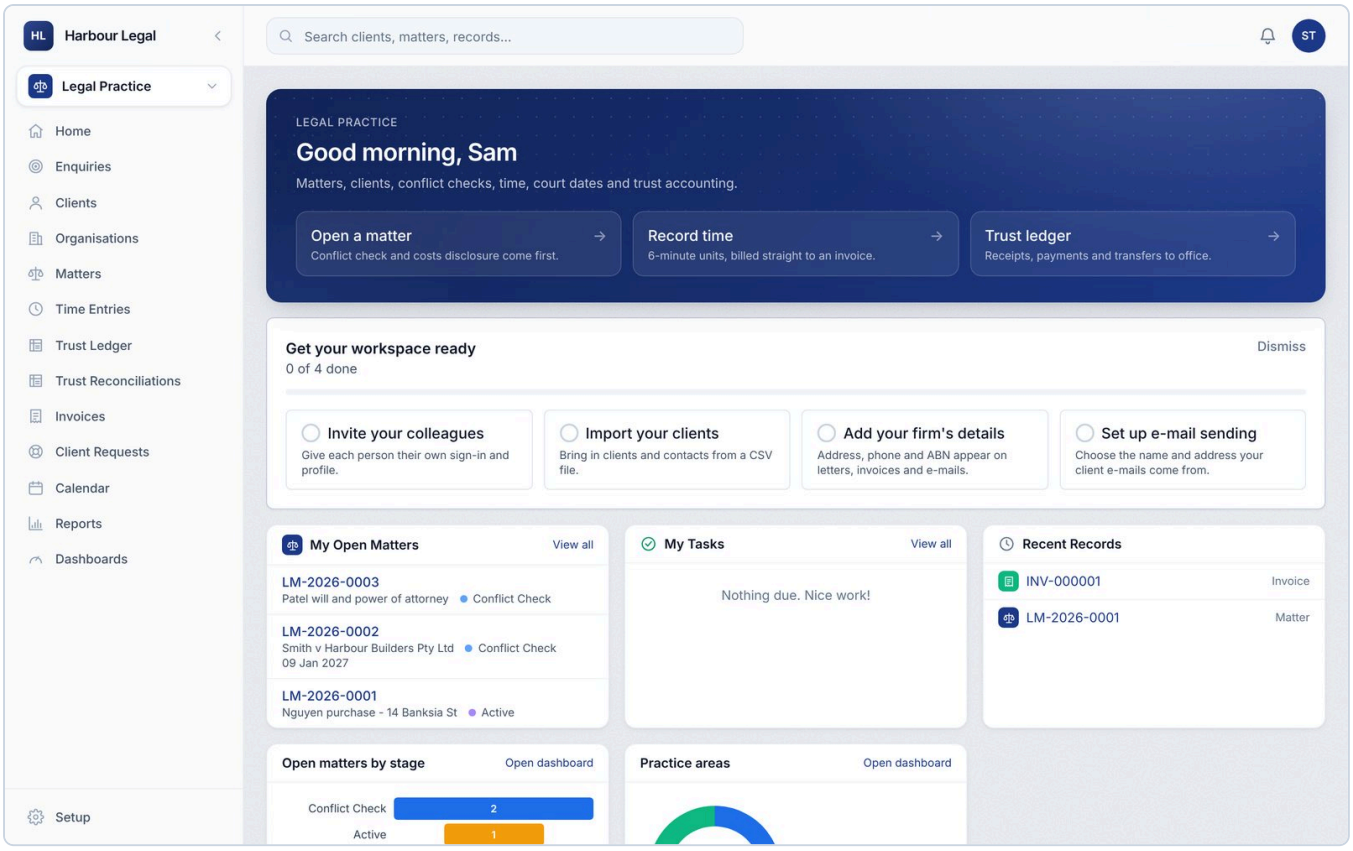


Figure 1: Home, with the Open a matter, Record time and Trust ledger shortcuts, My Open Matters and the dashboard charts.

3. Matters

Viewing matters

Open **Matters**. The table shows Matter Number, Matter Title, Client, Practice Area, Stage and Responsible Solicitor. Use the buttons beside the search box to switch to the **board view** (one column per stage). Click the list name to switch views:

- **All Matters**
- **My Matters:** your matters that aren't closed.
- **Open Matters**
- **Limitation Dates (90 days)**
- **Costs Disclosure Updates Due**

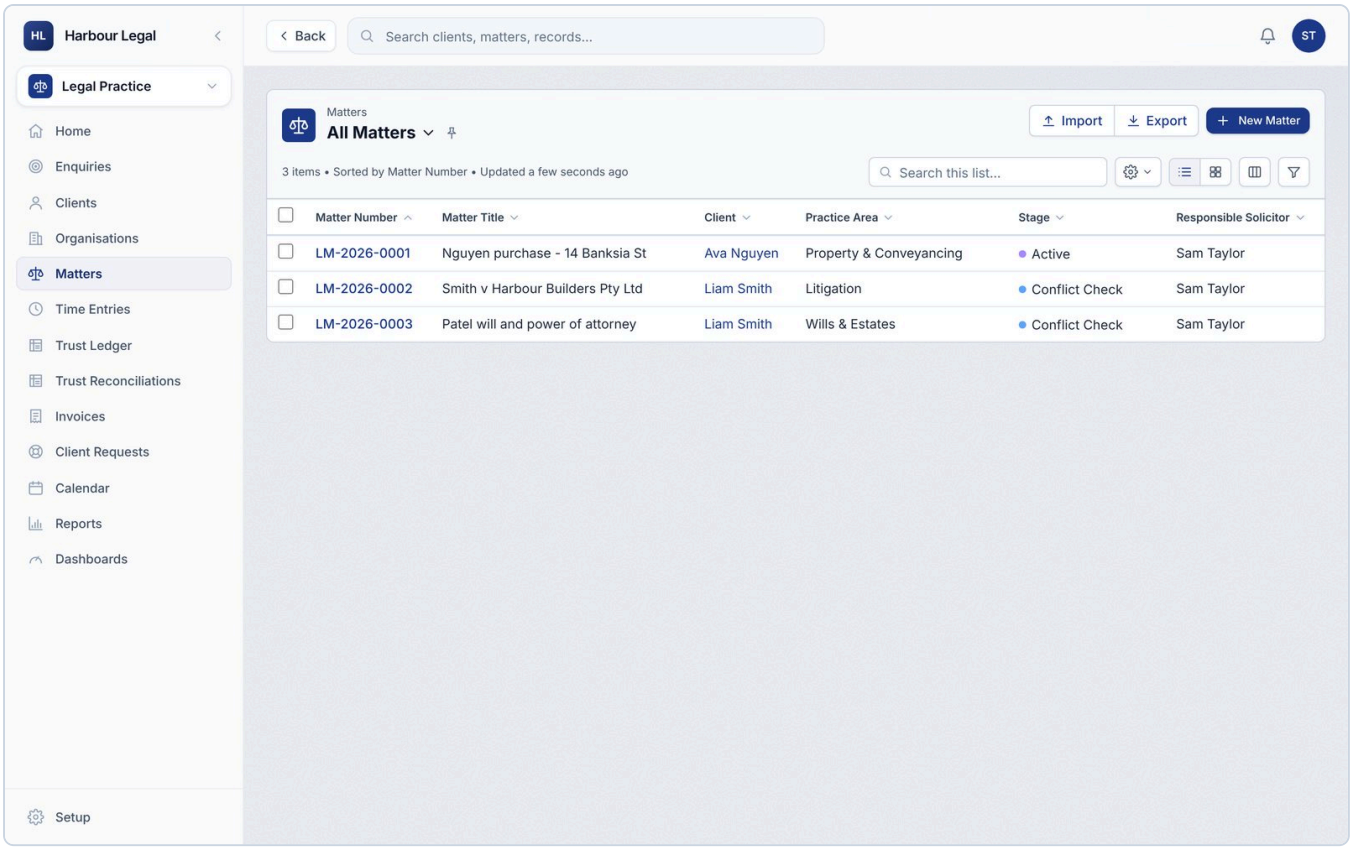


Figure 2: The Matters list.

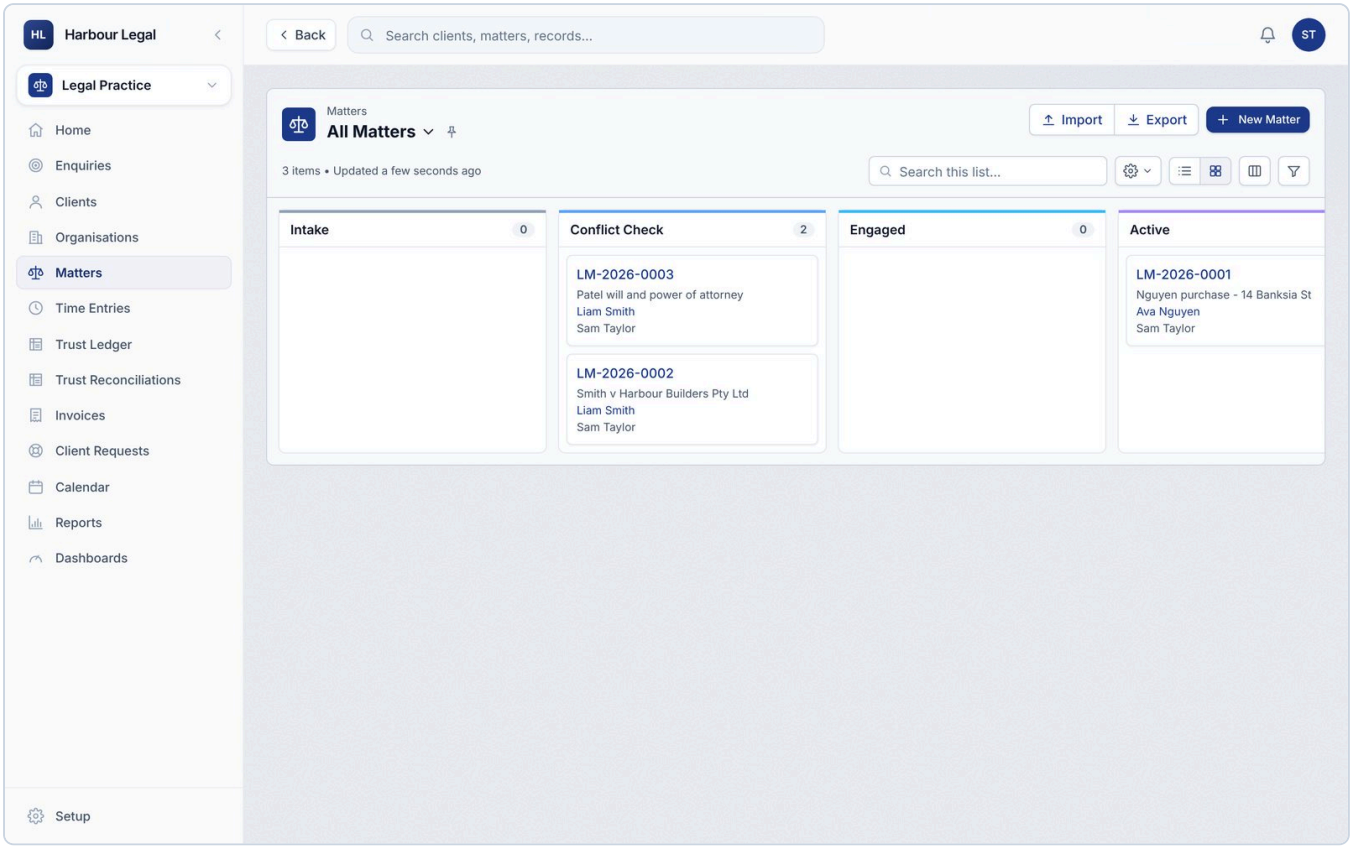


Figure 3: Matters in board view.

Step by step: opening a matter

1. In **Matters**, click **+ New Matter**.
2. Enter the **Matter Title** (required) and choose the **Client** (required).
3. Optionally choose a **Billing Organisation**, when a company pays rather than the client.
4. Choose the **Practice Area**: Family, Property & Conveyancing, Wills & Estates, Commercial, Litigation, Employment, Criminal, Personal Injury, Immigration or Other.
5. **Responsible Solicitor**: leave empty to make it you. Optionally add the **Supervising Principal**.
6. Add court details and the **Limitation Date** where relevant.
7. Under **Costs**, choose the Billing Method (Hourly, Fixed Fee, Conditional or Pro Bono) and the Client Type. Enter the Estimated Legal Costs, and the Agreed Fixed Fee for a fixed-fee matter. Leave the Hourly Rate empty to use the practice's default rate ($380 unless changed in Practice Settings).
8. Click **Save**. The matter gets the next number (for example **LM-2026-0001**), and a conflict check runs straight away (section 4).

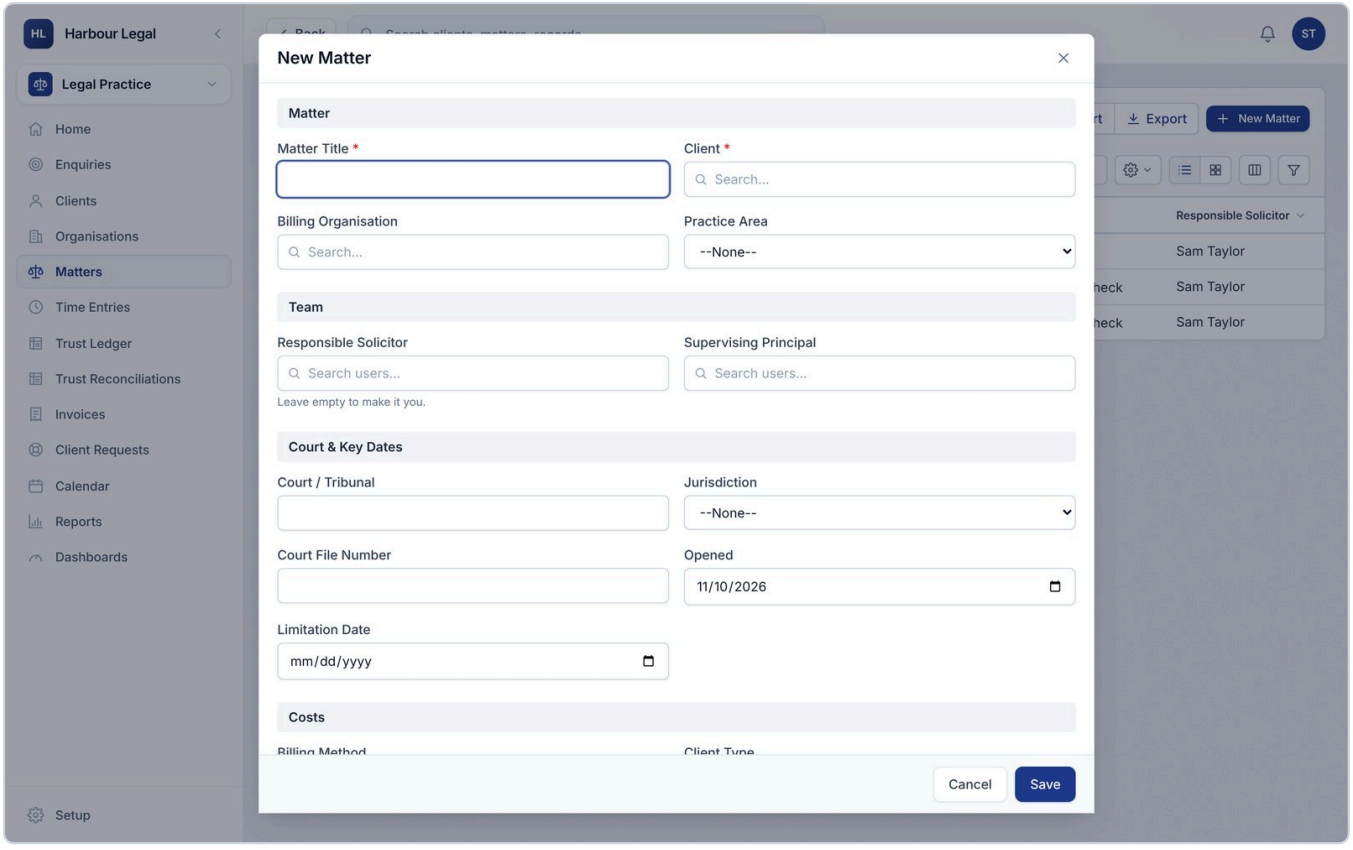


Figure 4: The New Matter form.

Matter stages

1. Intake
New matters start here

2. Conflict Check
Set automatically when the conflict check runs

3. Engaged
Needs conflicts cleared, costs disclosure, and VOI or a limitation date where required

4. Active

5. Settlement/Hearing

6. Closed
Needs no unbilled time and $0 in trust

To move to	The app requires
Engaged (or any later stage)	• **Conflict Cleared:** set by a Clear conflict check. • **Costs Disclosure Provided:** ticked, unless the matter is Pro Bono, the client is Commercial or Government (Uniform Law s 170), or the estimate is $750 or less (s 174). • **Property & Conveyancing:** the client's **Identity Verified** ticked (VOI). • **Personal Injury and Litigation:** a **Limitation Date**, or a Court File Number once proceedings are filed. The practice areas for VOI and limitation dates can be changed in Practice Settings.
Closed	No unbilled time (bill it or write it off) and a trust balance of $0. Closing sets the Status to Closed and records the Closed date.

Use **Mark Stage as Complete** on the stage path, or click a stage and **Mark as Current Stage**. The **Status** field (Open, On Hold or Closed) is separate from the stage. Setting it to Closed closes the matter, with the same checks.

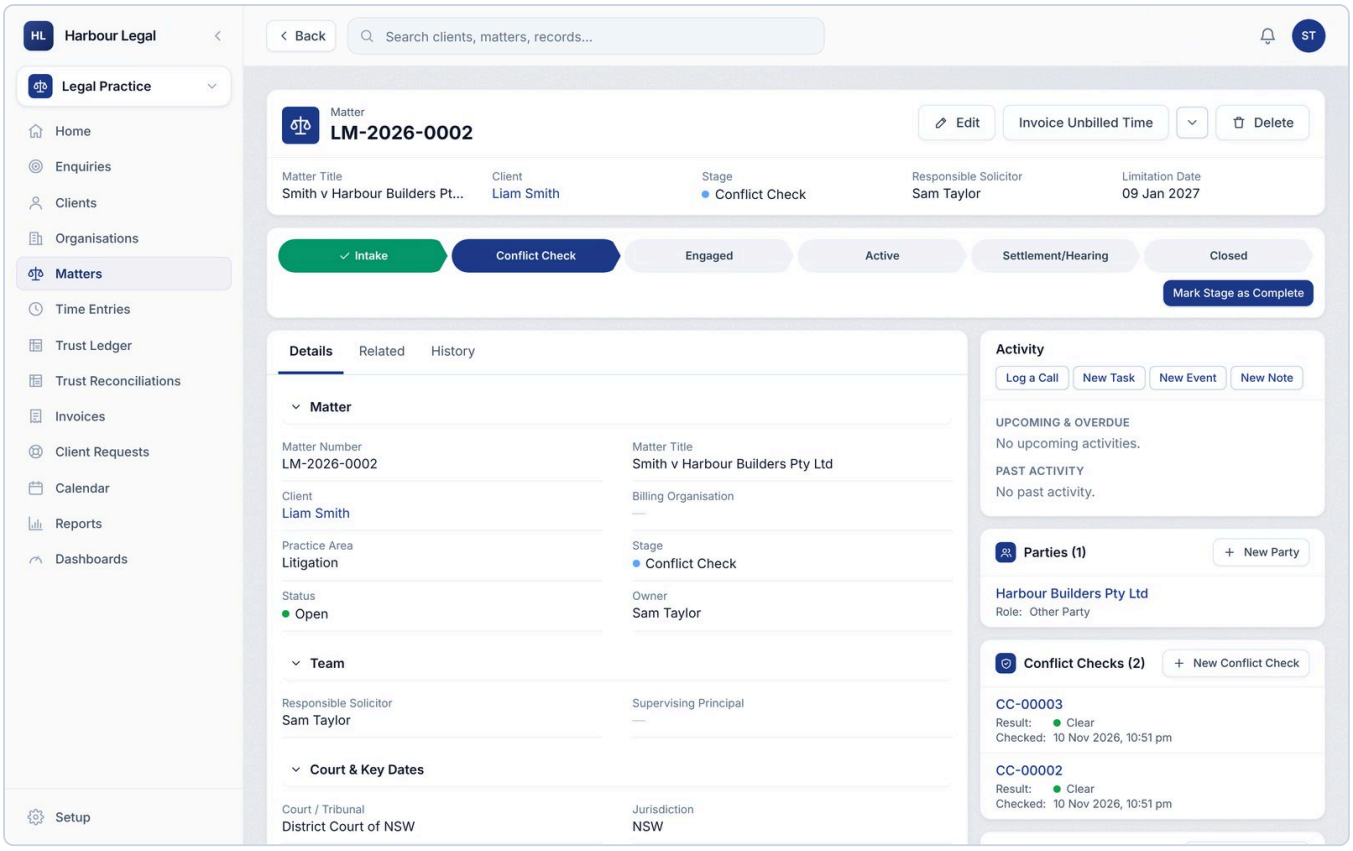


Figure 5: A matter: header, stage path, details, and the Parties and Conflict Checks lists.

4. Conflict Checks & Parties

A conflict check (**CC-00001**) runs automatically:

- **When a matter is opened:** it searches the client, the billing organisation and every party.
- **When a party is added:** it searches that party.

Each name is searched against other matters' parties (including former clients as opposing parties), and against existing clients, organisations and other matters.

- **No matches:** the check is **Clear** and the matter's **Conflict Cleared** is ticked.
- **Matches:** the check is **Potential Conflict**, the matches are listed in **Matches Found**, the responsible solicitor is notified, and Conflict Cleared is unticked.
- **Clearing a match:** only a **Principal** can mark a check with matches as Clear, and must first write the **Clearance Notes / Waiver**. The clearance is written to the audit log.
- **Searching again: Run Search Again** repeats the search, for example after correcting a name.

Adding parties

On the matter's **Related** tab, click **+ New Party**. Enter:

- the party's name;
- the **Role**: Other Party, Other Side's Lawyer, Related Party, Witness, Expert, Insurer or Guarantor;

- optionally a linked Contact or Organisation, and the **ACN / ABN**, which is matched exactly in conflict searches.

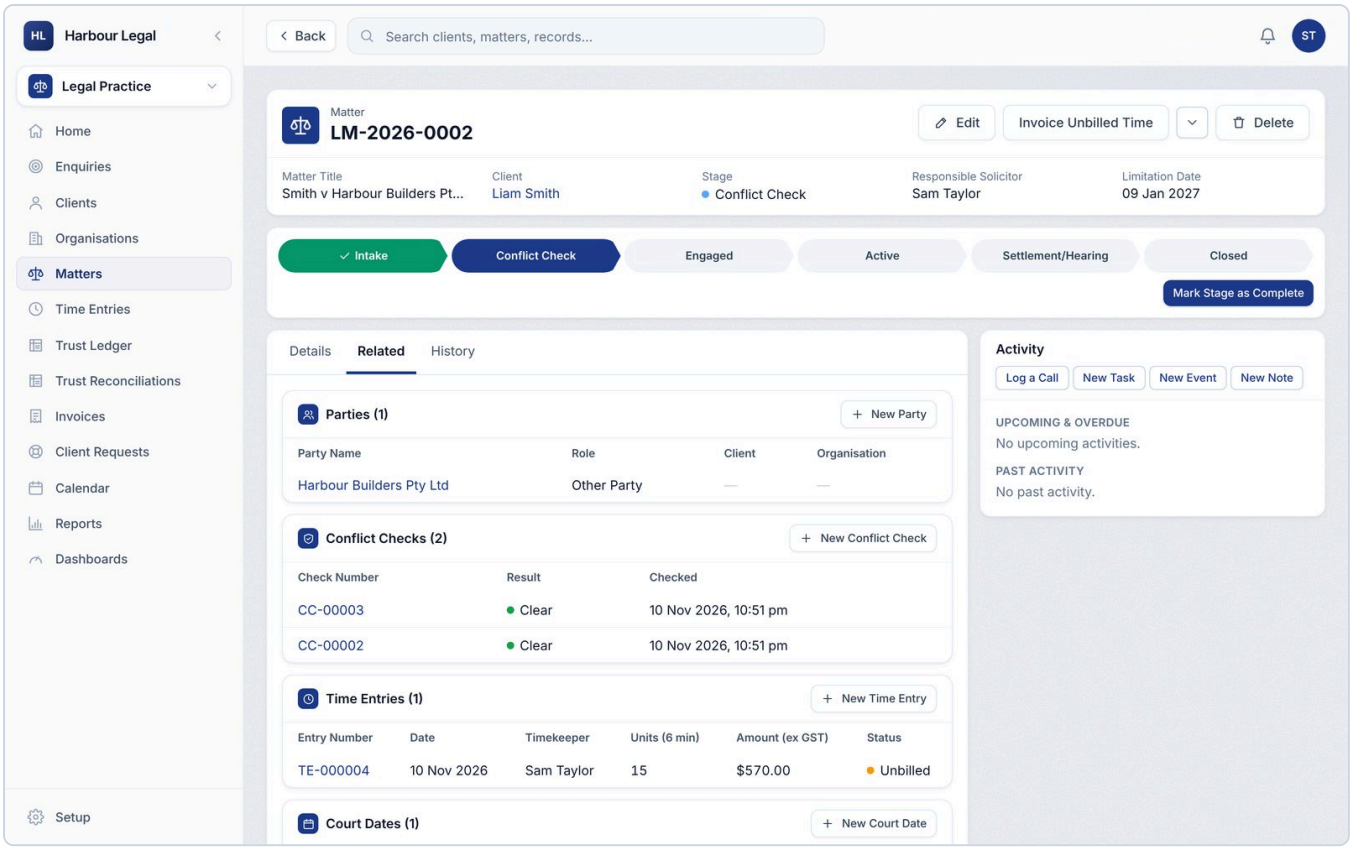


Figure 6: The Related tab of a matter: parties, conflict checks, time entries, court dates, trust ledger and invoices.

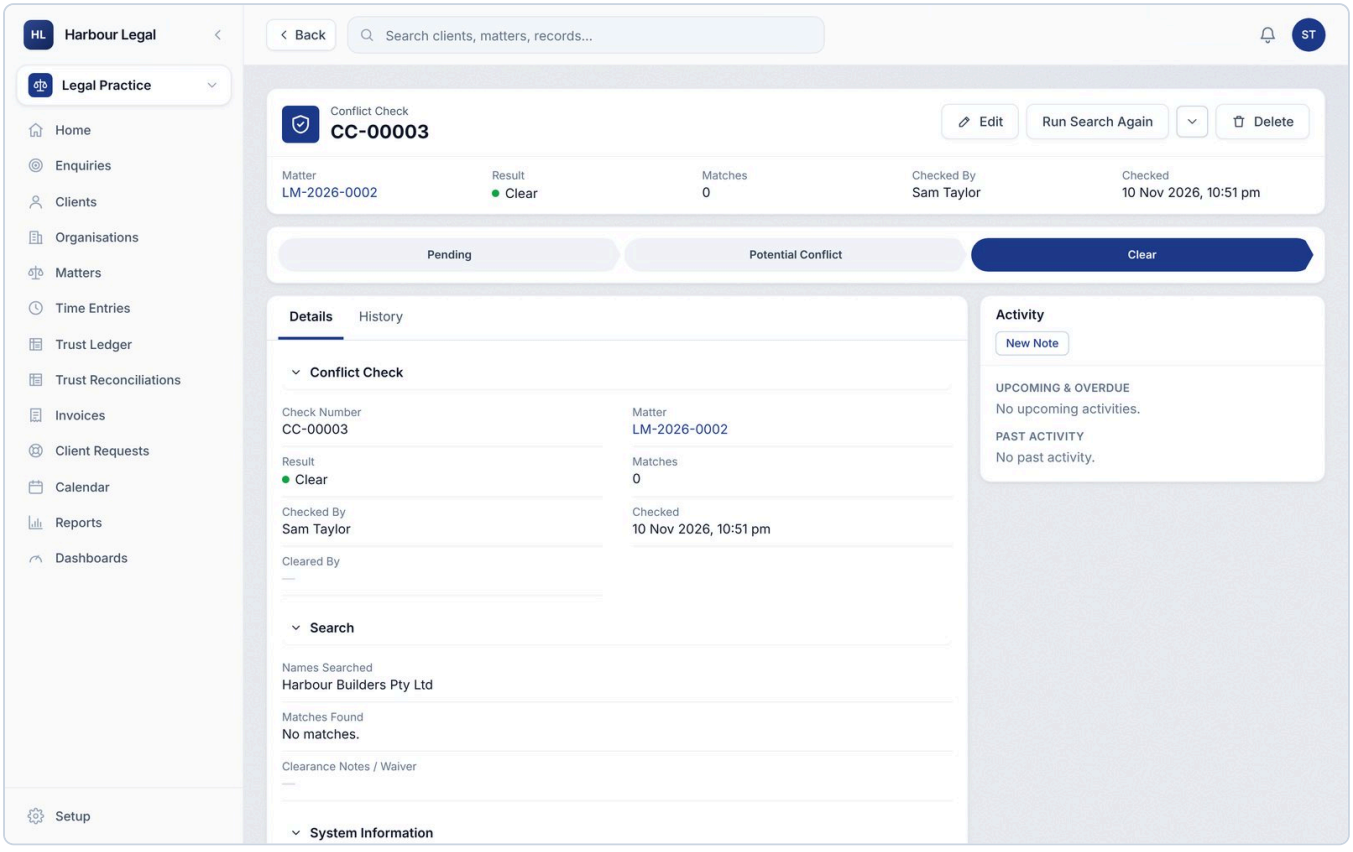


Figure 7: A conflict check, showing the names searched and the result.

5. Costs Disclosure

The matter's **Costs** section records the disclosure required by the Uniform Law:

- **Costs Disclosure Provided:** when ticked, the **Costs Disclosure Date** fills in with today.
- **Disclosure Given As:**
  - **Uniform Standard Disclosure Form:** only allowed while the estimate is $3,000 or less (s 174(5)).
  - **Full Written Disclosure:** required above $3,000, and the default.
- **Updated Disclosure Due:** ticked automatically, and the responsible solicitor notified, when the **Estimated Legal Costs** rise by 10% or more after disclosure (s 174(1)(b)). Give the client updated disclosure, then change the Costs Disclosure Date; this clears the flag.
- **Billed to Date (ex GST)** and **Unbilled Time (WIP)** are kept up to date by the app.

> **Billing is checked against the disclosure**
>
> Invoicing is refused while an updated disclosure is due. It's also refused when the bill would take the matter 10% or more past the estimate the client was given: disclose the revised estimate first. The 10%, $750 and $3,000 figures can be changed in Practice Settings.

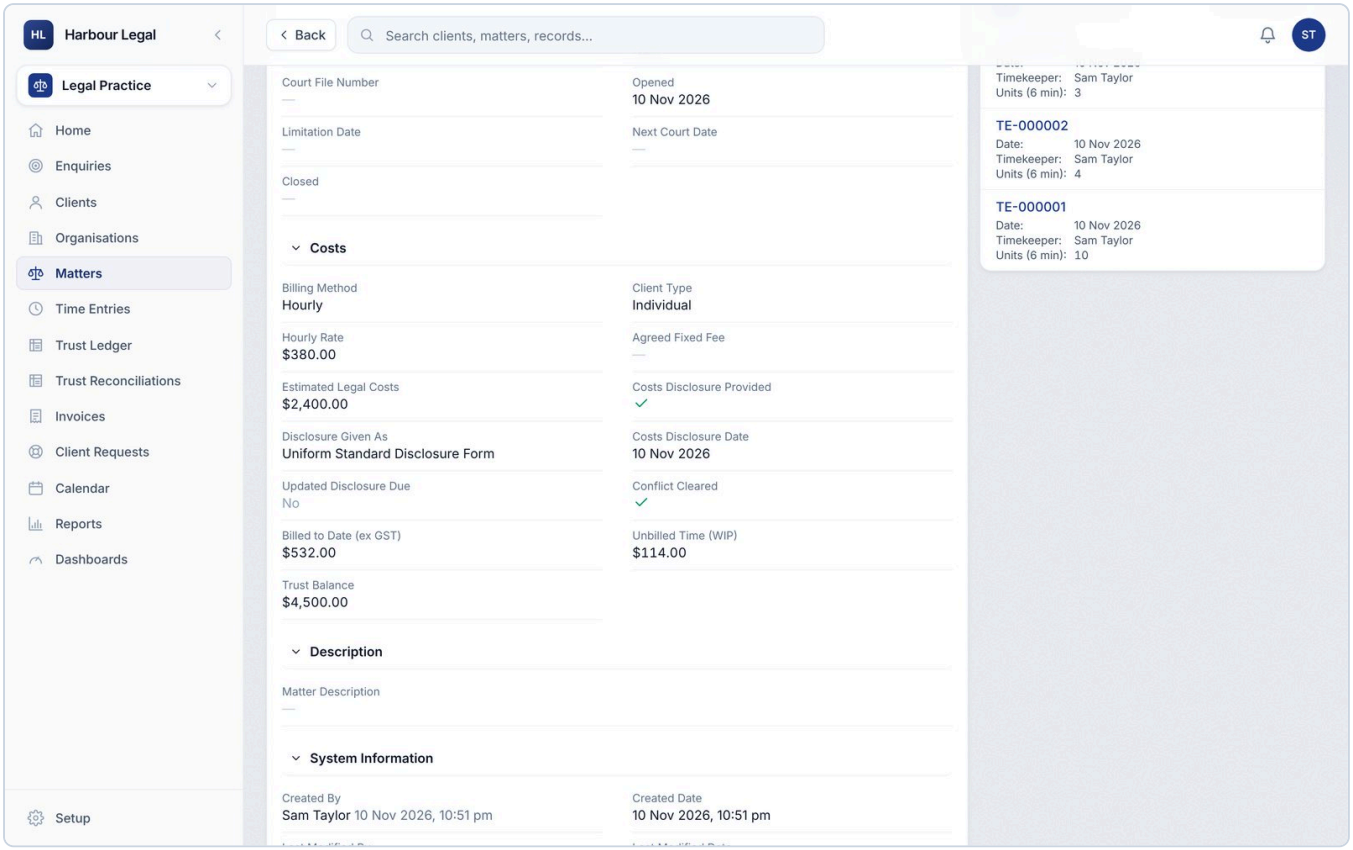


Figure 8: The Costs section of a matter with standard-form disclosure, WIP, billed to date and trust balance.

6. Time Recording & Billing

Step by step: recording time

1. Click **Record time** on Home, or **+ New Time Entry** in Time Entries (or on the matter's Related tab).
2. Choose the **Matter** and the **Date**. The **Timekeeper** defaults to you.
3. Enter **Units (6 min)**: 1 unit = 6 minutes, so 1.5 hours = 15 units. Choose an **Activity** and write the **Narrative** (required).
4. Leave the **Hourly Rate** empty to use the matter's rate. Untick **Billable** for non-chargeable time.
5. Save. The app calculates **Hours** and **Amount (ex GST)**, and adds billable time to the matter's WIP.

Time can't be recorded on a closed matter. Once an entry is **Billed** or **Written Off**, it can't be changed. A **Principal** can **Write Off** unbilled time, with a reason that's recorded in the audit log.

The Time Entries views are **My Time** and **Unbilled Time (WIP)**.

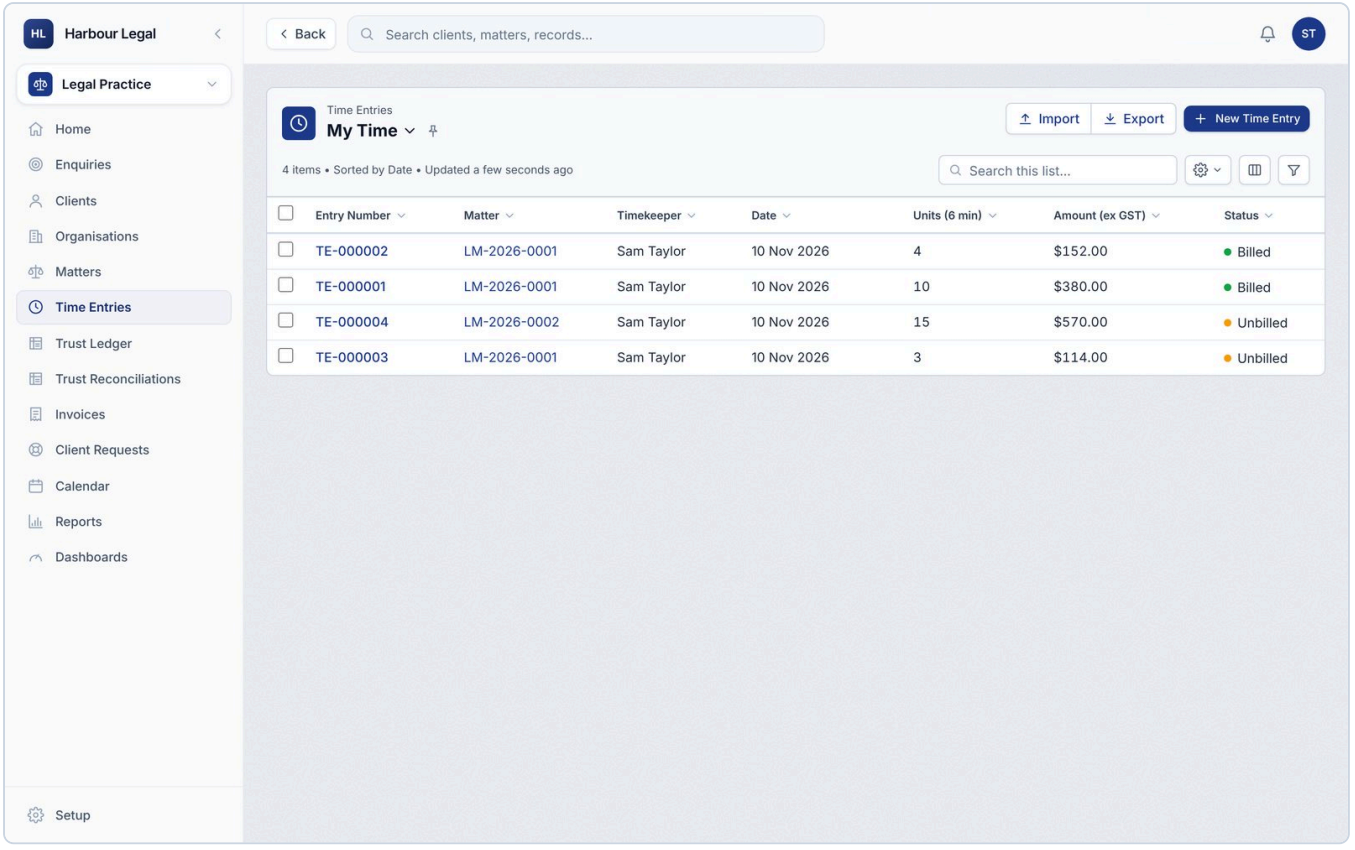


Figure 9: My Time, with billed and unbilled entries.

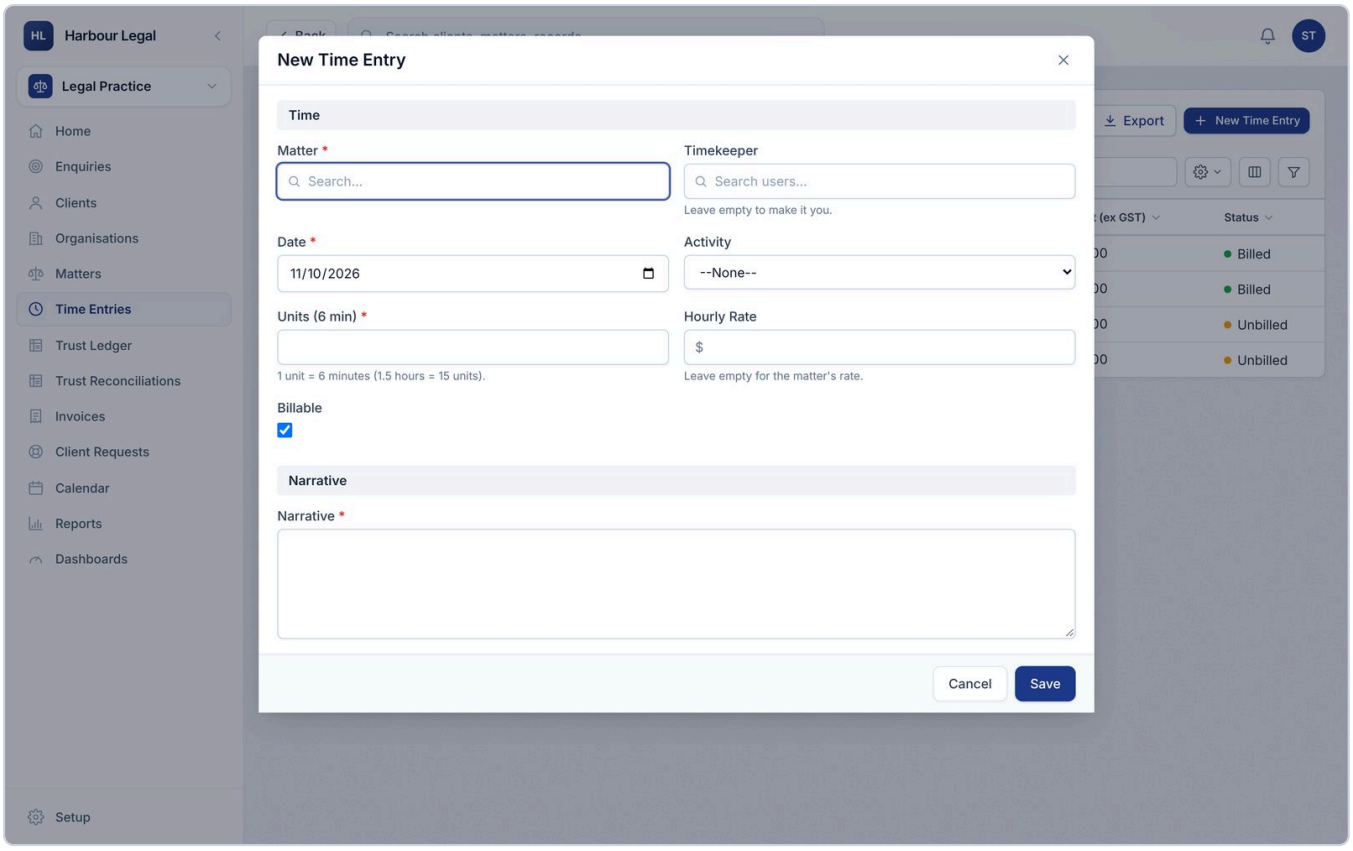


Figure 10: The New Time Entry form.

Step by step: invoicing a matter

1. On the matter, click the invoicing button:
   - **Invoice Unbilled Time:** for hourly matters. It creates a draft invoice with one line per unbilled billable entry and marks those entries Billed.
   - **Invoice Fixed Fee:** for fixed-fee matters. It creates one line for the Agreed Fixed Fee and absorbs the recorded time.
2. The invoice goes to the Billing Organisation or, for an individual, to the client in their own name.
3. Review the draft invoice, then click **Issue Invoice**. Issuing gives it its final number and locks the lines.

Before you can issue tax invoices, an administrator must add the practice's **ABN** in **Setup → Company & Branding**.

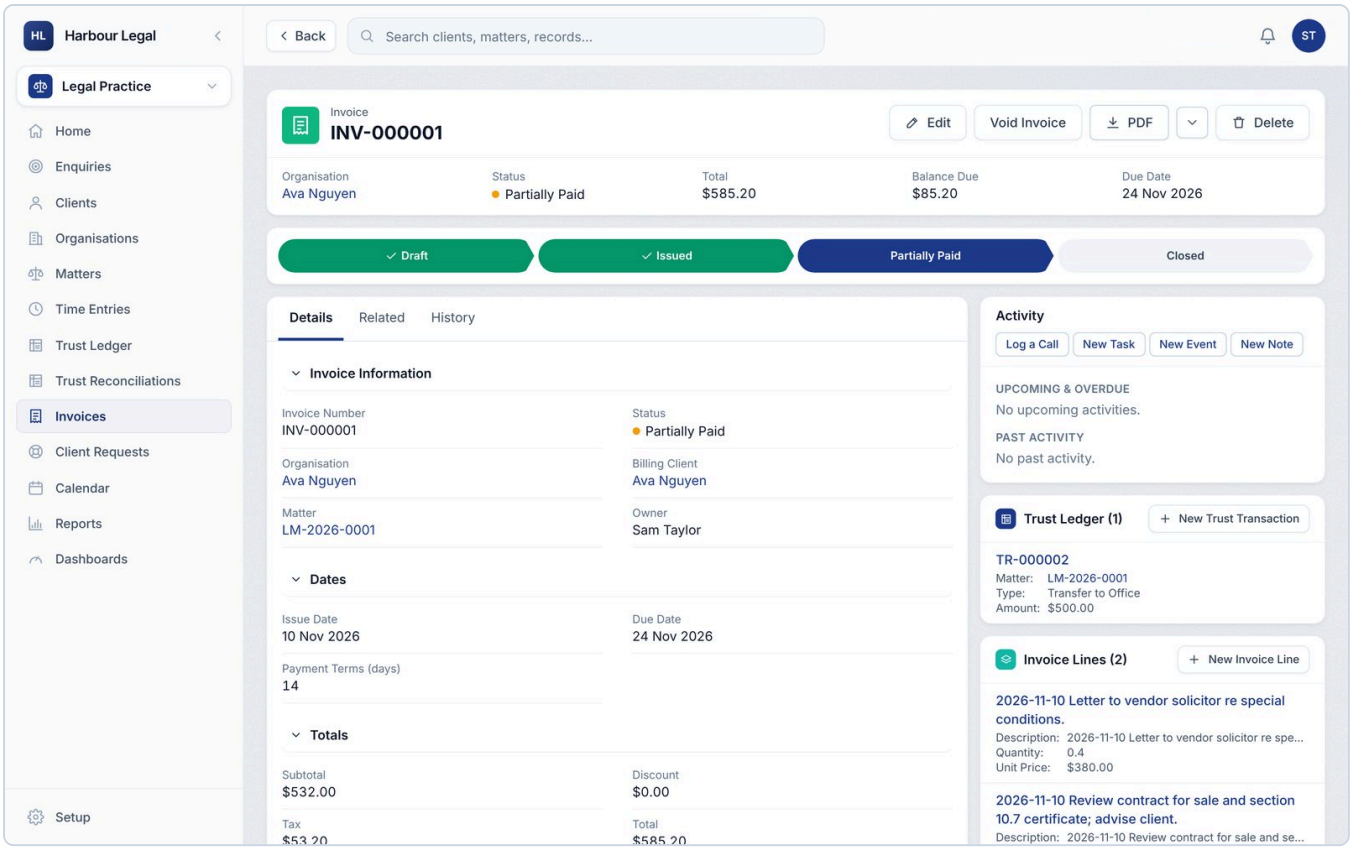


Figure 11: An issued invoice, part paid by a transfer from trust.

7. Trust Accounting

Recording trust money

Only people with **Manage Trust Account** (Principal and Trust Accountant) can record trust transactions. Click **+ New Trust Transaction** and choose:

- the **Matter** (the client fills in automatically);
- the **Type**: Receipt, Payment or Transfer to Office;
- the **Amount**, **Date**, **Paid By / Paid To** and **Purpose** (required);
- the **Method**: EFT, Cheque, BPAY, Cash or Card;
- a **Reference**.

Each transaction gets a number like **TR-000001**, and shows the matter's **trust balance after** it.

Trust rules the app enforces

- **No overdrawing:**
  a matter's trust balance can never go below $0, even when two people post at the same time.
- **How money goes out:**
  payments and transfers go out only by EFT, BPAY or cheque, never cash or card.
- **Transfer to Office:**
  must be linked to an **issued, unpaid invoice on the same matter**, and can't be more than its balance due. The payment is recorded on the invoice automatically.
- **Corrections:**
  trust records can't be edited or deleted after posting; record a correcting transaction instead. The one exception is the AUSTRAC report reference, which can be added later.
- **Large cash receipts:**
  a cash receipt of **$10,000 or more** creates a high-priority task to report the significant cash transaction to AUSTRAC within 15 business days. Record the report reference on the receipt; the **Cash Receipts (AUSTRAC)** view lists them.

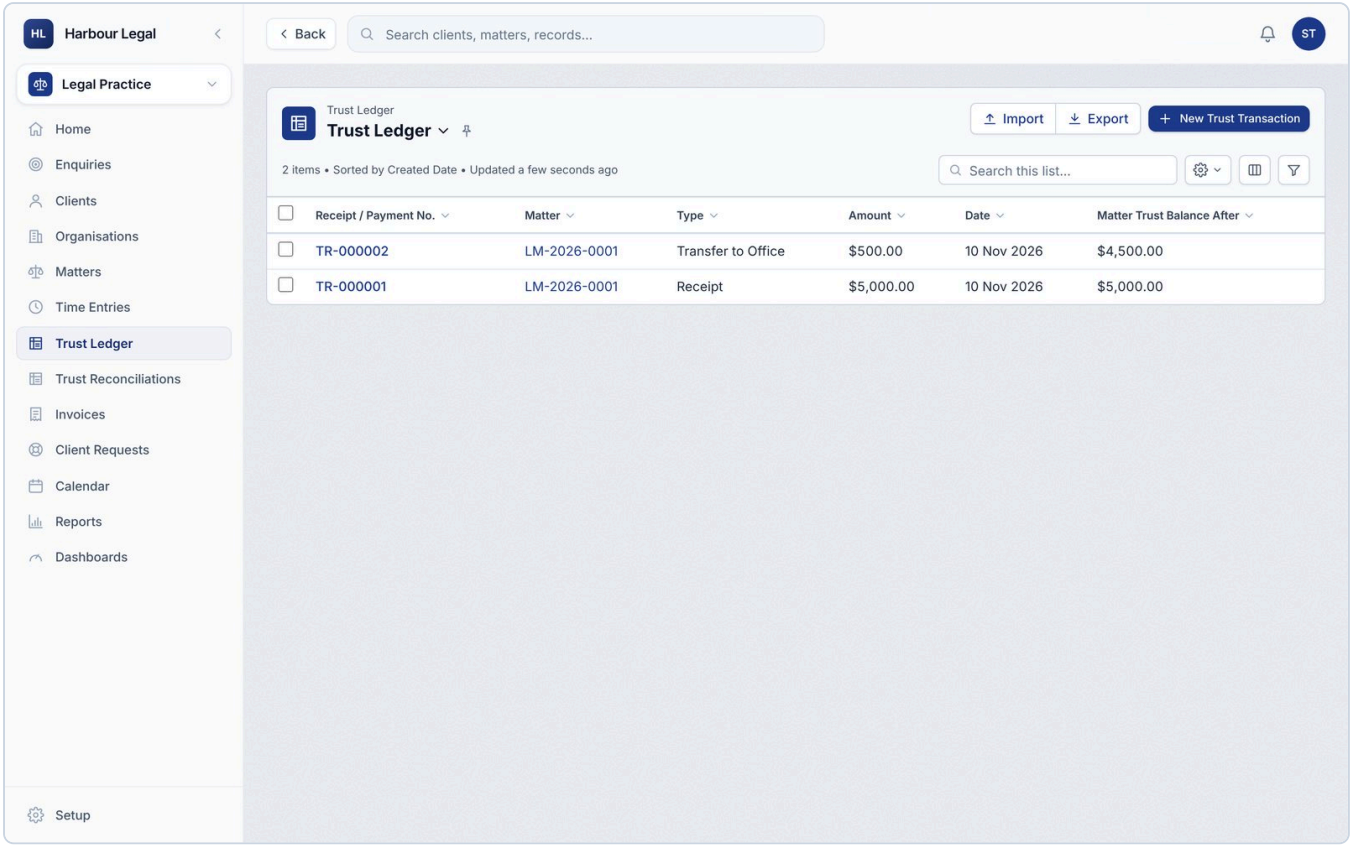


Figure 12: The Trust Ledger, with a receipt and a transfer to office.

Trust statement

On a matter, open the ▾ menu and choose **Trust Statement**. It shows every transaction with the running balance; print it or save it as a PDF to give to the client.

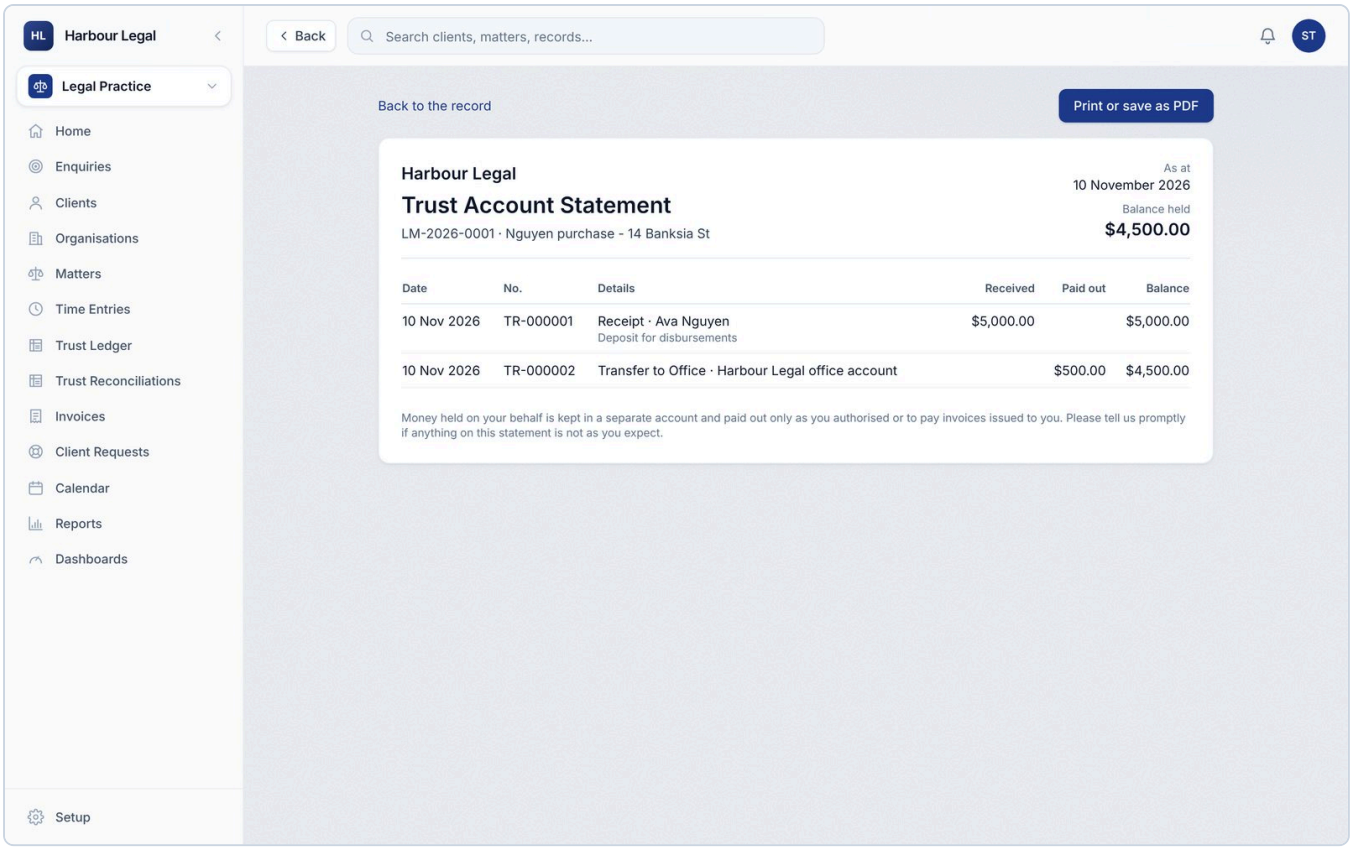


Figure 13: A trust account statement for one matter.

Monthly trust reconciliation

1. In **Trust Reconciliations**, click **+ New Trust Reconciliation**.
2. **Month Ending:** choose the last day of the month. Each month can be reconciled only once.
3. Enter the **Trust Bank Statement Balance**, and any **Unpresented / Uncleared Items** (negative for unpresented cheques, positive for deposits not yet credited).
4. The app calculates the **Total of Matter Ledgers** up to that date and the **Difference**. Explain any items in the notes.
5. A **Principal** marks it **Reconciled**. This is only possible when the Difference is $0, and the reconciliation can't be changed afterwards.

From the 10th of each month, principals and trust accountants are reminded until the previous month is reconciled. The Uniform General Rules require it within 15 working days of month end.

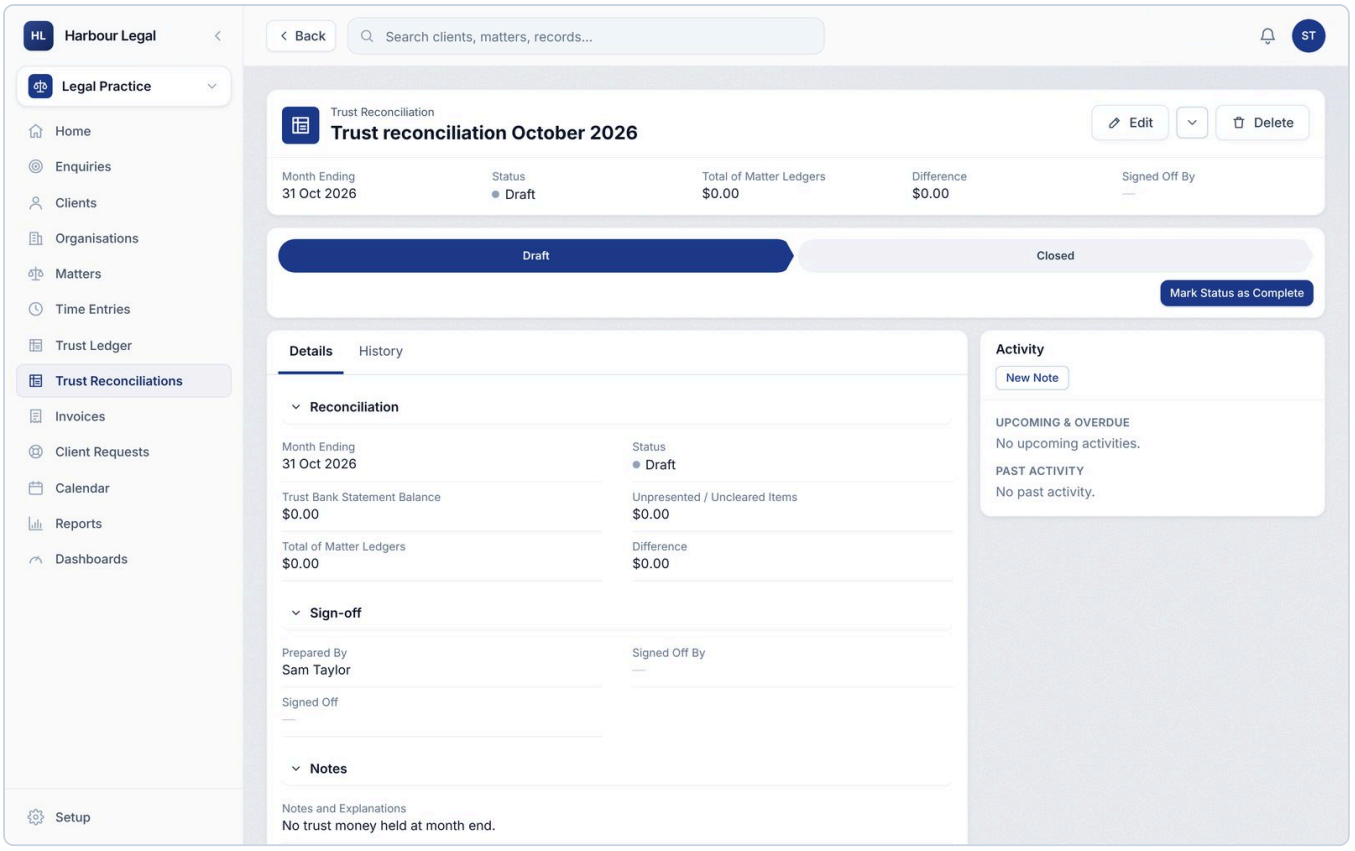


Figure 14: A trust reconciliation ready for sign-off.

8. Court Dates, Limitation Dates & Reminders

Add court dates on the matter's Related tab (**+ New Court Date**). Each has:

- a **Type**: Mention, Directions, Hearing, Trial, Mediation, Conciliation, Judgment or Filing Deadline;
- the **Date and Time**, Court and Courtroom;
- the person **Appearing**;
- **Visible to Client**, which shows the date in the client portal.

The matter's **Next Court Date** updates automatically.

Reminder	Default	Who is notified
Limitation date	90, 30 and 7 days before	The responsible solicitor, while the matter is open
Court date	7 and 1 days before	The person appearing
Trust reconciliation	From the 10th of the month	Principals and Trust Accountants
Updated costs disclosure	When the estimate rises 10% or more	The responsible solicitor
Possible conflict	When a check finds matches	The responsible solicitor

9. Clients & the Client Portal

A client's **Identity** section holds:

- **Date of Birth**;
- **Identity Verified:** tick it once you've completed verification of identity;
- **Identity Verified On**.

Organisations have an **ACN**. A client's record lists their matters, client requests and invoices. Contact details include **Mobile Number** and **Landline / Office Phone**.

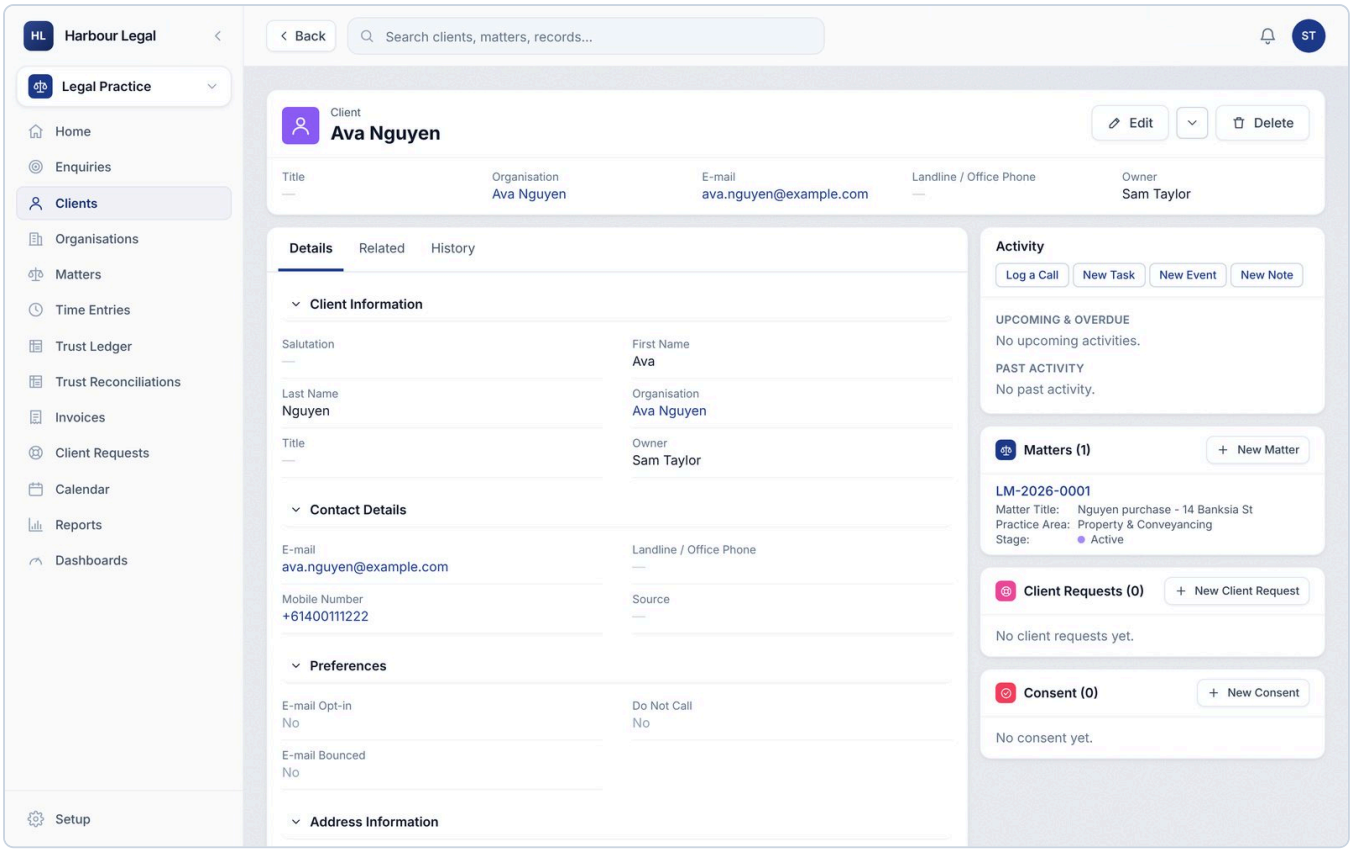


Figure 15: A client with identity verified and their matter.

To give a client portal access, open the ▾ menu on their record and choose **Invite to Client Portal**. In the portal they can:

- **See their matters:** stage, practice area and solicitor. The supervising principal, rates, conflict, WIP, billed-to-date and internal notes stay hidden.
- See court dates marked **Visible to Client**.
- View and download their issued invoices.
- Send requests to the firm, which appear under **Client Requests** and notify staff.

10. Reports & Dashboards

The **Practice Dashboard** (also on Home) shows open matters by stage, practice areas, work in progress, billable hours this month and upcoming limitation dates.

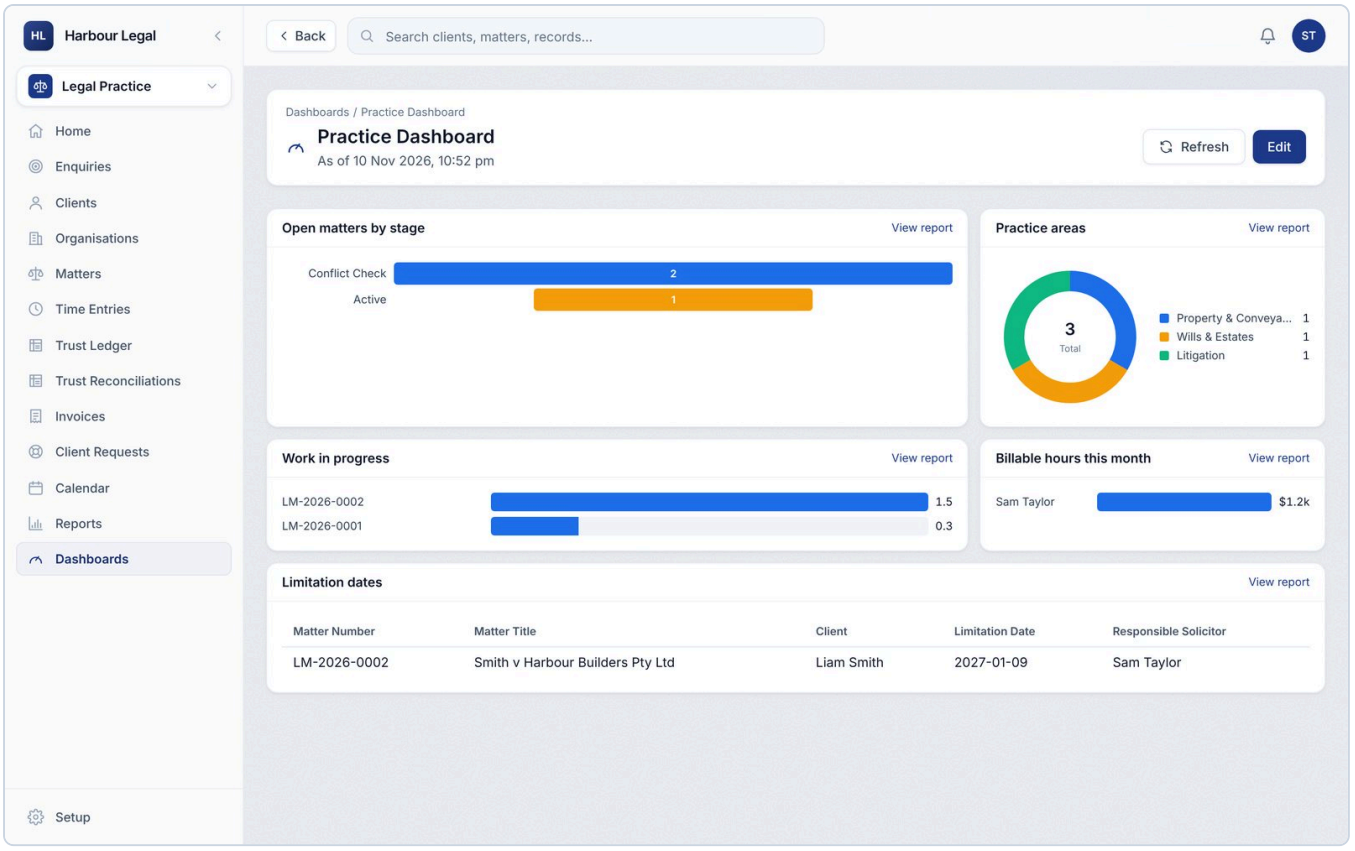


Figure 16: The Practice Dashboard.

The **Legal Practice Reports** folder contains:

Report	What it shows
Open Matters by Stage	Number of open matters at each stage
Matters by Practice Area	Open matters per practice area
Work in Progress (Unbilled Time)	Unbilled billable time by matter: amount and hours
Billable Hours by Timekeeper	This month's billable hours and value per person
Trust Balances by Matter	Money held in trust for each matter
Limitation Dates (next 90 days)	Matters with a limitation date coming up
Solicitor Workload	Open matters per responsible solicitor

Open a report to see its chart and totals, **Export** it, or **Subscribe** to have it e-mailed on a schedule.

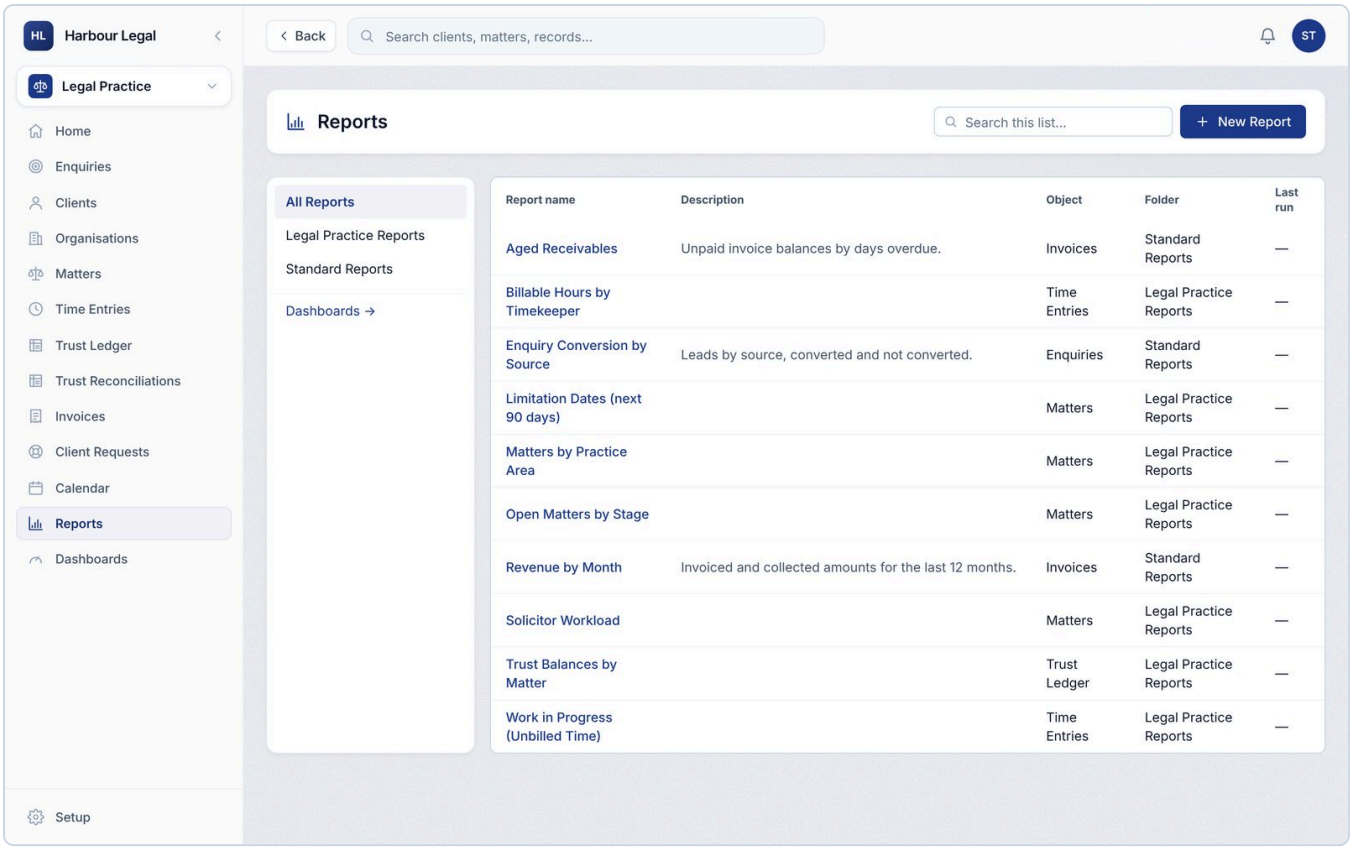


Figure 17: The Reports list.

11. Practice Settings

An administrator sets these in **Setup → Practice Settings → Legal Practice (Australia)**:

Setting	Default
Default hourly rate	$380
Costs disclosure threshold	$750
Uniform standard disclosure form limit	$3,000
Significant change in costs	10%
Significant cash transaction	$10,000
Identity verification required for	Property & Conveyancing
Limitation date required for	Personal Injury, Litigation
Limitation date reminders	90, 30, 7 days before
Court date reminders	7, 1 days before

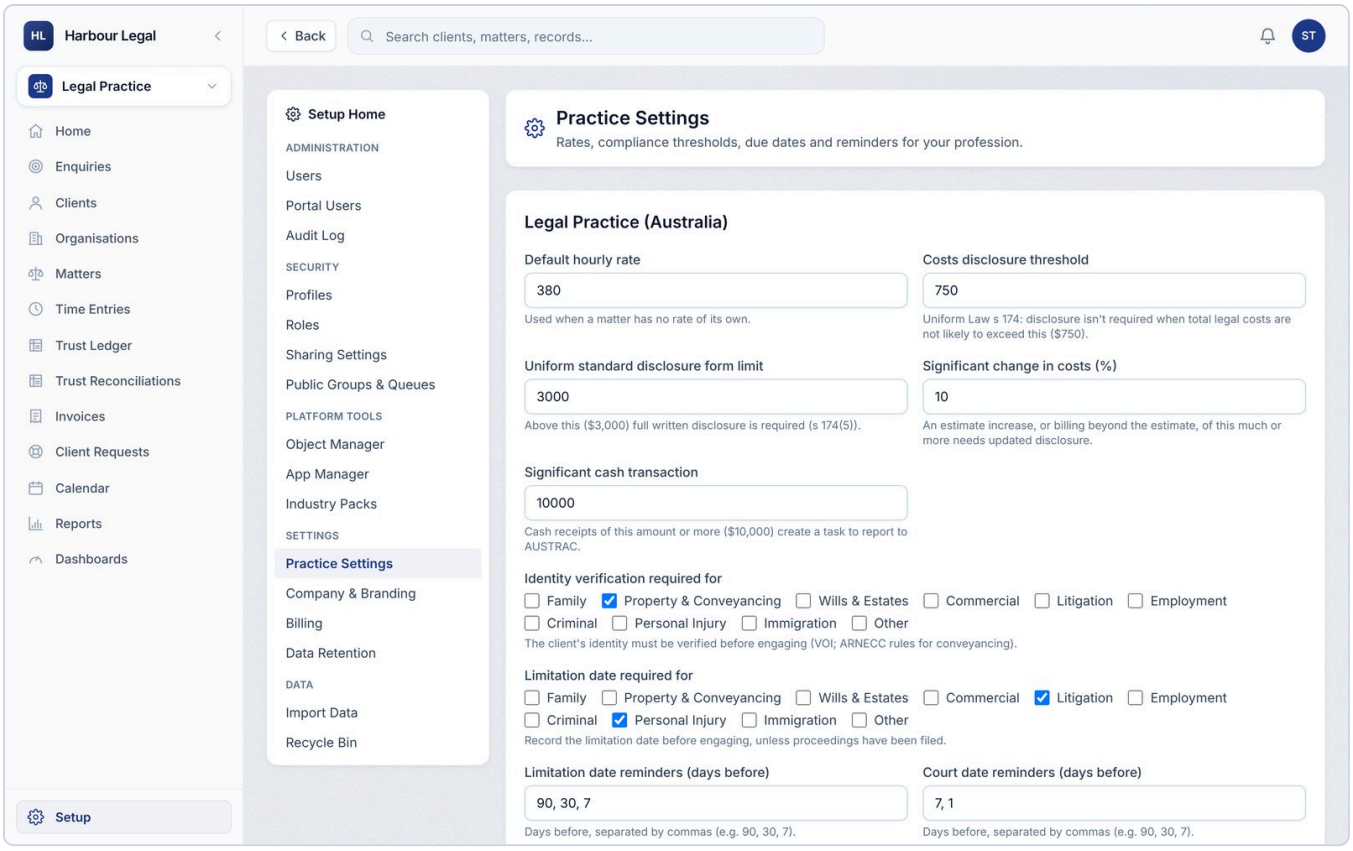


Figure 18: Practice Settings for the Legal Practice module.

12. Record Keeping & Audit

- **Retention:** a matter with time or trust records can't be deleted; it must be kept (7-year retention). Close it instead.
- **Trust records:** they can't be changed or deleted, and signed-off reconciliations are locked.
- **History:** each record's **History** tab shows changes to key fields (stage, status, client, responsible solicitor, limitation date, costs and disclosure fields, conflict result) with who made them and when.
- **Audit log: Setup → Audit Log** records sign-ins, changes, conflict clearances, write-offs, exports and other actions, with the user, time and IP address.

13. Frequently Asked Questions

Q1: Why can't I move a matter to Engaged?

The message names the missing step. It's one of these:

- the conflict check isn't Clear;
- costs disclosure isn't recorded (and the estimate is over $750 for a non-commercial client);
- the client's identity isn't verified on a conveyancing matter;
- there's no limitation date on a litigation or personal injury matter.

Q2: The conflict check found matches. What now?

Review the Matches Found. If there's no real conflict, or the client has given informed consent, a Principal writes the Clearance Notes / Waiver and sets the Result to Clear. If there is a conflict, set it to Conflict and don't act.

Q3: Why was invoicing refused?

Either an updated costs disclosure is due, or this bill takes the matter 10% or more past the disclosed estimate. Give the client updated disclosure, update the estimate and the Costs Disclosure Date, then invoice.

Q4: Why can't I transfer trust money to office?

A transfer must be linked to an issued, unpaid invoice on the same matter, can't be more than its balance due, and can't exceed the matter's trust balance.

Q5: I entered a trust receipt incorrectly. How do I fix it?

Trust records can't be edited. Record a correcting transaction (for example, a Payment back to the payer, with the reason in the Purpose) so the ledger keeps a full history.

Q6: Why can't I close the matter?

Bill or write off the unbilled time, and pay out or transfer any money still held in trust, so the trust balance is $0.

14. Best Practice Summary

Phase	Best practice
Intake	Add every party before engaging, so the conflict check covers them; verify identity for conveyancing.
Engagement	Give costs disclosure before work starts and record the method; record the limitation date on claims.
Running the matter	Record time daily with clear narratives; update the estimate and disclose changes as soon as costs move.
Trust	Receipt money on the day; transfer to office only against issued invoices; reconcile every month by the 15th working day.
Closing	Bill or write off remaining time, account for all trust money, then close the matter.